

11 Coping With Conflict: When Relational Partners Disagree

Mary and Doug catch their teenage daughter, Amanda, smoking after school with her friends. Because Mary is convinced that Amanda's friends are a bad influence on her, she wants to ground Amanda for a month, making her come home immediately after school. Doug, however, thinks grounding will be more of a punishment for the parents than Amanda because she will be moping around the house complaining all the time and arguing with her twin sister, Megan. Instead, Doug proposes that they deduct the cost of a carton of cigarettes from Amanda's weekly allowance for the next 6 months. Mary objects, saying that she does not want Amanda to be motivated to change her behavior because of money. Both parents feel strongly that their punishment is best, leading to a disagreement.

If you were Amanda's parent, how would you want to handle this situation? From Amanda's perspective, which punishment would most likely be effective? Are there other types of punishment—besides grounding or reducing Amanda's allowance—that might actually be more effective? What conflict management styles might Mary and Doug use to deal with this situation, and are there any conflict behaviors that are especially destructive?

Contrary to popular perception, conflict is not inherently good or bad. Depending on how people manage conflict, disagreement can either make a relationship stronger or weaker. Indeed, the literature on interpersonal conflict demonstrates that people have a variety of options for dealing with conflict. Some of these options involve cooperating and managing conflict productively and effectively. Other options are aggressive and competitive, which can lead to distress and exacerbation of the problem. Effective conflict management is essential for maintaining a healthy and happy relationship.

In this chapter, we examine how relational partners cope with disagreement. First, we define conflict and discuss the role conflict plays in close relationships, including those between spouses, family members, friends, and romantic partners. Next, we turn our attention to how people communicate during conflict situations. We review six conflict styles—(1) **competitive fighting**, (2) **compromising**, (3) **collaborating**, (4) **indirect fighting**, (5) **avoiding**, and (6) **yielding**. We also discuss patterns of communication, such as negative reciprocity and demand-withdraw. The chapter ends with practical rules for constructive conflict management.

Conflict in Relationships

Think about all the positive and negative experiences you have had with close friends, family members, and romantic partners. As you reflect on these experiences, can you think of a close relationship of yours that has not included some conflict or disagreement? If you can, that relationship is the exception to the rule.

Defining Conflict

Notice that we asked you to try and think of a close relationship that did not include some level of conflict or disagreement. When people think about “conflict” in their relationships, they usually imagine angry voices, name-calling, and relationship problems. However, conflict is more synonymous with the term *disagreement* than with yelling or arguing. People can engage in conflict by using positive forms of communication during disagreements, such as collaboration and compromise. Voices can be calm, negative emotions muted, positions can be validated, and relationships can be strengthened instead of weakened. In line with these ideas, Hocker and Wilmot (2013) defined **conflict** as “an expressed struggle between at least two interdependent parties who perceive incompatible goals, scarce resources, and interference from others in achieving their goals” (p. 13).

When people are interdependent, a lack of compatibility can interfere with each person’s ability to reach personal goals. Understandably, some forms of incompatibility are more important than others. Hocker and Wilmot (2013) argued that incompatibility will likely lead to a struggle when rewards are scarce. The various issues linked to conflict in different relationships, as listed in [Box 11.1](#), highlight incompatibility as the central theme. In addition, conflict is most likely when incompatible goals are important to both people and are difficult to obtain because there is interference from one another or from others. For example, you can imagine Amanda (a teenager) wanting to stay out later than her parents want her to (curfew); Amanda and her sister, Megan, arguing about who gets more space in the bedroom closet they share (territory); and Amanda’s parents arguing over how to best discipline her for smoking (children). In all of these cases, someone is interfering with someone else’s goals. Amanda’s parents are preventing her from staying out as late as she wants and Megan is trying to limit her closet space. Mary and Doug are getting in the way of how they each think Amanda should be punished.

Box 11.1 Highlights: Common Conflict Issues in Various Relationships

Parents and Young Children	Parents and Teenagers	Siblings	Married Couples
Possessions	Curfew	Possessions	Household Labor
Caretaking*	Friends	Privacy	Money and Possessions
Hurtful Behavior**	Dating Patterns	Parental Attention	Jealousy/Possessiveness
Rules and Manners	Privacy	Territory	Sex
Need for Assistance***	Lifestyle Choices		Children

Frequency of Conflict in Various Relationships

Conflict is most likely to occur in the context of close relationships. In a study by Argyle and Furnham (1983), people rated different relationships in terms of frequency of conflict and degree of emotional and relational closeness. Spouses reported the most closeness but also the most conflict. Indeed, most romantic couples have between one and three disagreements per week, with one or two disagreements per month being particularly unpleasant (Canary et al., 1995). Unhappy couples often experience much more conflict; one study found that distressed couples reported having 5.4 conflicts over a 5-day period (see Canary et al., 1995). Yet another study showed that conflict increased as relational partners became more committed and interdependent (Lloyd & Cate, 1985). Together these studies make an important point: Although too much conflict may reflect relational problems, some level of conflict is normal and healthy in close relationships. As we shall see later, the way people manage conflict is even more important than the frequency of conflict. In Argyle and Furnham's study, family relationships, including parents and children or siblings, were also high in both conflict and closeness. Conversely, relationships between neighbors were low in both conflict and closeness. Across the life span, conflict is more likely to occur within family and romantic relationships than friendships or work relationships (Sillars, Canary, & Tafoya, 2004). In parent–child relationships, the most conflict tends to occur when children are toddlers or teenagers. One study showed that disputes between mothers and their 18- to 36-month-old children occurred around seven times per hour, with about half of these disputes being brief and the other half lasting longer and being more competitive (Dunn & Munn, 1987). During the teenage years, around 20% of parents and adolescents complain that they have too much conflict with one another. When children reach late adolescence and early adulthood, conflict typically declines (Paikoff & Brooks-Gunn, 1991).

Like conflict between parents and children, conflict between siblings is often intense during early childhood and adolescence (Arliss, 1993). Same-sex siblings of about the same age are particularly likely to engage in frequent, competitive fighting. In fact, adolescent siblings are unlikely to compromise with one another. Instead, their conflict often ends in a standoff or in intervention by another family member or friend (Laursen & Collins, 1994). Yet siblings also share a unique bond. They usually know each other most of their lives; the

sibling relationship predates romantic relationships and typically outlives parent–child relationships. Many siblings not only survive stormy periods of conflict but also develop a close and special bond as adults.

Effects of Conflict on Relationships

The way people manage conflict is more important than how much people disagree. Of course, when partners argue a lot, it could be a sign that there are unresolved problems in the relationship. Frequent arguing is also associated with more use of aggressive communication, with aggressive communication tied to low levels of relationship satisfaction. One study found that wives who reported high levels of marital conflict were almost one and a half times more at risk for divorce than were wives who reported less conflict (Orbuch, Veroff, Hassan, & Horrocks, 2002). However, the destructiveness of conflict was an even more potent predictor of divorce, and this finding was consistent across both husbands and wives, with couples who reported yelling, exchanging insults, and criticizing one another more likely to divorce (Orbuch et al., 2002). Couples who argue frequently and in an aggressive manner also report reduced commitment (Knee, Patrick, Vietor, & Neighbors, 2004).

Marital conflict can have harmful effects on children as well as spouses. Children who witness their parents engaging in frequent, aggressive conflict are more likely to have trouble interacting with their peers and performing at their full potential in school (Buehler et al., 1997; Sillars et al., 2004). Research on this **spillover effect** suggests that these negative effects arise because parents who engage in dysfunctional conflict are also likely to have dysfunctional parenting styles (Davies & Cummings, 1994). A **socialization effect** is also likely to occur, with children adopting conflict styles similar to their parents' conflict styles (Koerner & Fitzpatrick, 2002; Reese-Weber & Bartle-Haring, 1998). A study by Kitzmann and Cohen (2003) examined several aspects of interparental conflict: frequency (how often parents argue in front of them), intensity (how mad parents get when they argue with each other), perceived threat (how scared children get when their parents argue), and resolution (how long parents stay mad at each other beyond the actual argument). Their results showed that children in Grades 3 through 6 were less likely to report having a high-quality relationship with a best friend if their parents had trouble resolving their conflicts. Frequency, intensity, and threat were less predictive of poor friendship quality than resolution, underscoring how important it is for parents to manage conflict rather than holding grudges and remaining angry. Studies have also shown that children actually fare better when feuding parents divorce compared to when they stay together and engage in increasingly negative patterns of conflict communication (Caughlin & Vangelisti, 2006).

Despite these negative effects, conflict can be beneficial when it is managed productively. Gottman's (1979, 1994) research shows that satisfied couples are more likely to discuss issues of disagreement, whereas dissatisfied couples are likely to minimize or avoid conflict. By confronting disagreement, relational partners can manage their differences in ways that enhance closeness and relational stability (Braiker & Kelley, 1979; Canary et al., 1995; Lloyd & Cate, 1985). Couples who handle conflict in a calm, collaborative fashion tend to be satisfied with their relationships and are less likely to divorce (McGonagle, Kessler, & Gotlib, 1993). A study by Siegert and Stamp (1994) examining the effects of a couple's "first big fight" also underscores the important role that conflict plays in relationship development. Partners who stayed together after the fight

gained a greater mutual understanding of their feelings, felt they could solve problems together, and were confident that they would both be willing to make sacrifices for each other. By contrast, partners who broke up after the fight reported feeling uncertain about their relationship. During the fight, many people discovered negative information about their partners, and many felt that future interaction would be tense and uncomfortable. More than anything, however, the way partners perceived and handled conflict predicted whether their first big fight would signal the end of their relationship or a new beginning. In addition, the way partners manage conflict is a better predictor of relational satisfaction than is the experience of conflict itself. Being able to resolve conflict so that both parties are satisfied with the outcome is also predictive of relational satisfaction (Cramer, 2002).

Conflict Styles

Considerable research has focused on the strategies or styles that people use to deal with conflict in organizations (Blake & Mouton, 1964; Putnam & Wilson, 1982; Rahim, 1986; Rahim & Bonoma, 1979) and in relationships between friends, lovers, and roommates (Fitzpatrick & Winke, 1979; Klein & Johnson, 1997; Sillars, 1980; Sillars et al., 2004). Research in both these areas suggests that conflict styles can be distinguished by two dimensions: cooperation and directness (Rahim, 1986; Sillars et al., 2004). Cooperative conflict takes both partners' goals into account, whereas uncooperative conflict focuses on one person trying to win the argument. Direct conflict involves engaging in conflict and talking about issues, whereas indirect conflict involves avoiding discussion of conflict. Researchers have developed several typologies of conflict styles from these dimensions, with some scholars identifying three styles (e.g., Putnam & Wilson, 1982; Sillars, 1980), other scholars finding four styles (e.g., Klein & Johnson, 1997; Sillars et al., 2004), and still other scholars discovering five styles (e.g., Blake & Mouton, 1964; Rahim, 1986). A review of the strategies in these typologies suggests that there are six styles of conflict: (1) competitive fighting, (2) compromising, (3) collaborating, (4) indirect fighting, (5) avoiding, and (6) yielding (see [Figure 11.1](#)). Notice that only two of these six styles are labeled as "fighting." This is because only two of the styles are inherently competitive and aggressive. The other styles all represent nonaggressive ways to express disagreement and manage conflict. To determine your own conflict style, complete the scale in [Box 11.2](#).

Figure 11.1 Interpersonal Conflict Styles

Direct	Competitive Fighting	Compromising	Collaborating
Indirect	Indirect Fighting	Avoiding	Yielding



Uncooperative **Cooperative**

Competitive Fighting

Competitive fighting is direct and uncooperative (Blake & Mouton, 1964). This style has been called *direct fighting* (Sillars et al., 2004), *distributive* (Sillars, 1980), *dominating* (Rahim, 1986), *controlling* (Putnam & Wilson, 1982), and *contentious* (Klein & Johnson, 1997; Pruitt & Carnevale, 1993). As these labels suggest, people with a competing style try to control the interaction so they have more power than their partner. They attempt to achieve a win-lose situation, wherein they win and their partner loses. In their attempts to achieve dominance, individuals who employ competing strategies use several tactics: confrontational remarks, accusations, personal criticisms, threats, name-calling, blaming the partner, sarcasm, and hostile jokes (Sillars

et al., 2004).

Imagine that Mary and Doug both used competitive fighting when trying to determine how to punish Amanda. They might cling stubbornly to their own perspectives, with each arguing that their method is superior to the other partner's. Mary might accuse Doug of being too selfish to put up with Amanda being at home all the time because she is grounded, and Doug might claim that Mary's past attempts at grounding Amanda have been unsuccessful and that "everyone knows" she is too lenient. The conflict could very well escalate, with Mary and Doug yelling at each other and calling each other names. Even if one of them eventually yields, the desired win-lose outcome likely will be only temporary (Kilmann & Thomas, 1977). In the long run, Mary and Doug's relationship could be harmed, leading to a lose-lose situation for both.

Box 11.2 Put Yourself to the Test: What Is Your Conflict Style?

Think about the last few times you and a relational partner disagreed. How did you behave? Use the following scale to determine your typical conflict style: 1 = strongly disagree and 7 = strongly agree.

	Strongly Disagree				Strongly Agree			
1. I discuss the problem to try to reach a mutual understanding.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
2. I keep arguing until I prove my point.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
3. I show my partner that I am angry or upset without saying a word.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
4. I sometimes sacrifice my own goals so my partner can meet her or his goals.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
5. I try to find a new solution that will satisfy both our needs.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
6. I usually try to win arguments.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
7. I do not like to talk about issues of disagreement.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
8. I am willing to give up some of my goals in exchange for achieving other goals.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
9. I try to get all my concerns and my partner's concerns out in the open.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
10. I try to get back at my partner by giving the silent treatment or holding a grudge.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
11. I usually try to forget about issues of disagreement so I don't have to confront my partner.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
12. I try to think of a solution that satisfies some of both our needs.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
13. Sometimes I find myself attacking my partner.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
14. I use facial expressions to let my partner know I am angry or upset.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
15. It is important to get both our points of view out in the open.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
16. Sometimes I criticize my partner to show that he or she is wrong.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
17. I try to meet my partner halfway.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
18. If the issue is very important to my partner, I usually give in.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
19. I attempt to work with my partner to find a creative solution we both like.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
20. I tend to show negative feelings through nonverbal communication, such as rolling my eyes.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
21. I usually let my partner take responsibility for bringing up conflict issues.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
22. I would rather not get into a discussion of unpleasant issues.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
23. I give in to my partner to keep my relationship satisfying.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
24. I try to make my partner see things my way.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
25. I avoid bringing up certain issues if my arguments might hurt my partner's feelings.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
26. I might agree with some of my partner's points to make my partner happy.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
27. I am likely to give my partner cold or dirty looks as a way of expressing disagreement.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
28. I avoid talking with my partner about disagreements.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
29. I try to find a "middle ground" position that is acceptable to both of us.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
30. I believe that you have to "give a little to get a little" during a disagreement.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
To obtain your results, add your scores for the following items:								
Yielding: Items 4 + 18 + 23 + 25 + 26 =				_____				
Avoiding: Items 7 + 11 + 21 + 22 + 28 =				_____				
Collaborating: Items 1 + 5 + 9 + 15 + 19 =				_____				
Competitive fighting: Items 2 + 6 + 13 + 16 + 24 =				_____				
Compromising: Items 8 + 12 + 17 + 29 + 30 =				_____				
Indirect fighting: Items 3 + 10 + 14 + 20 + 27 =				_____				

Higher scores indicate that you possess more of a particular conflict style.

As this example illustrates, the competing strategy is usually associated with poor communication competence and reduced relational satisfaction (Canary & Spitzberg, 1987, 1989, 1990; Gross & Guerrero, 2000; Sillars, 1980). People who use competing strategies are typically ineffective in meeting their goals and inappropriate in their treatment of their partner. There are exceptions to this, however. In relationships where a power differential exists, such as those between managers and employees or between parents and children, strategies related to competitive fighting are sometimes effective. For instance, if a father wants to prevent his son from engaging in dangerous behavior, he might force him to stay home while his friends attend a rowdy party. The competing strategy is most useful when immediate compliance is necessary (Hocker & Wilmot, 2013). The competing strategy may also be useful when it is important to deal with a particular conflict issue. For instance, if one partner does not want to talk about a critical problem (e.g., how to deal with the financial fallout of the wife being laid off from her job), the other partner may engage in competing behaviors to force the partner to confront the issue. In other cases (e.g., finding out one's partner flirted with an ex-lover all night at a party), people may be justified in expressing anger or leveling accusations at their partners. Usually, however, competitive fighting leads to a conflict escalation and harms relationships, especially if positive communication does not counterbalance verbal aggression (Canary & Lakey, 2006).

Compromising

The compromising style is direct and moderately cooperative (Blake & Mouton, 1964; Kilmann & Thomas, 1977; Rahim, 1986). Compromise involves searching for a fair, intermediate position that satisfies some of both partner's needs. With compromise, people need to give something up to reach a solution that will meet at least some of their goals. Thus, compromise usually leads to a part-win-part-lose situation. Indeed, people who compromise talk about "splitting the difference" and "meeting the partner halfway." According to Hocker and Wilmot (2013), compromising behaviors include appealing to fairness, suggesting a trade-off, maximizing wins while minimizing losses, and offering a quick, short-term resolution to the conflict. Mary and Doug could reach this type of resolution by deciding to ground Amanda for 2 weeks instead of a month and deduct cigarette money from her allowance for 3 months instead of 6. This way, Mary and Doug both get to administer the punishment they perceive as appropriate, but neither applies the punishment for as long as they originally proposed. In short, they get to keep something but they also have to give up something.

Research suggests that the compromising style is generally perceived to be moderately appropriate and effective (Gross & Guerrero, 2000). Although this style is not as effective or appropriate as the collaborating style that is discussed next, there are situations in which compromising is best. Suppose a couple is arguing over whom to ask to be godparents for their son. The husband wants his sister and brother to be godparents, while the wife prefers her favorite aunt and uncle. Assuming their son can only have two official godparents, the couple might decide to put names in a hat, with one slip of paper appointing the aunt and brother as godparents and the other designating the sister and uncle. Such a compromise is likely to be seen as fair by all parties. As Hocker and Wilmot (2013) described, most people perceive compromising to be a reasonable, fair, and efficient strategy for managing conflict, even though it requires some sacrifice and hampers the

development of creative alternatives. When a compromise is seen as unfair, it can lead to dissatisfaction. In one study, violent couples actually used more compromise than satisfied couples (Morrison, Van Hasselt, & Bellack, 1987). Thus, although compromise is usually a moderately effective conflict strategy, if couples have to compromise too often, they may feel that their needs are not being met and their problems are never truly resolved.

Collaborating

The collaborating style is direct and cooperative (Blake & Mouton, 1964). This style has been called *integrating* (Rahim, 1986; Sillars, 1980), *solution oriented* (Putnam & Wilson, 1982), *problem solving* (Klein & Johnson, 1997; Pruitt & Carnevale, 1993), and *negotiation* (Sillars et al., 2004). As these labels suggest, the collaborating style focuses on cooperative problem solving that helps people find creative solutions that satisfy both partners' needs and lead to a win-win situation. Collaborating is a better option than compromising because both people have met their goals rather than each person having to give up something in order to get something. Another difference between the compromising and collaborating styles is that compromising usually involves modifying preexisting solutions, whereas collaborating involves creating new solutions. The collaborating style opens lines of communication, increases information seeking and sharing, and maintains relationships for future interaction (Hocker & Wilmot, 2013). Tactics associated with the collaborating style include expressing agreement, making descriptive or disclosive statements, being supportive, accepting responsibility, brainstorming ideas, and soliciting partner opinions (Sillars et al., 2004).

So how might Mary and Doug use a collaborating style? A starting point would be to share their concerns and search for a creative way to teach Amanda about the dangers of smoking. By using collaborative tactics, Doug might discover that Mary's main motivation is to keep Amanda away from the "bad" crowd she has been spending time with lately. Mary might discover that Doug's main objection to grounding is that it will not teach Amanda anything about the negative consequences of smoking. Doug might also realize that reducing Amanda's allowance by the cost of several cartons of cigarettes will only teach Amanda about the monetary cost of smoking, not the health risks. They might agree that it would be better if they required Amanda to volunteer some time after school at the local hospital, where she can help patients with lung cancer. Such a disciplinary action will keep Amanda away from her new friends (meeting Mary's needs) while also teaching Amanda about the risks associated with smoking (meeting Doug's needs). In fact, this new solution might address each of their concerns better than their original plans would have.

Of the six styles, the collaborating style is evaluated as the most effective and appropriate in managing conflict (Canary & Spitzberg, 1987, 1989, 1990; Gross & Guerrero, 2000; Gross, Guerrero, & Alberts, 2004).

Couples who use collaborating styles and show positive affect during conflict are likely to be happier, and children benefit from parents who use this conflict style (Caughlin & Vangelisti, 2006; Koerner & Fitzpatrick, 2006). Collaborating is related to perceptions of competence and relational satisfaction because it gives each individual access to the partner's views of so-called incompatible goals, allowing disputants to reach understanding and to co-construct meaning. When such understanding occurs, problems can be defined, and a solution that integrates the goals and needs of both parties can be reached (Tutzauer & Roloff, 1988). In

one study, parents and children reported being more satisfied with their relationships if they reported using the collaborating style to cope with conflict (La Valley & Guerrero, 2012). In another study, people reported using cooperative strategies to manage conflict in online relationships if the relationship was close and they wished to continue interacting with their partner in the future (Ishii, 2010). In some cases, it may be easier to be collaborative online because people have more time to think things through before communicating.

Indirect Fighting

Sillars and his colleagues (2004) refer to conflict behaviors that are indirect and uncooperative as indirect fighting. These behaviors have also been called *passive aggression* (Guerrero, 2013) and *active distancing* (Bachman & Guerrero, 2006a) and are related to patterns of negative withdrawal (Gottman, 1994). Examples of indirect fighting include failing to acknowledge or validate the partner's concerns, ignoring the partner, holding a grudge, using a whiny voice, giving the partner cold or dirty looks, angrily leaving the scene, rolling one's eyes, and administering the silent treatment (Guerrero, 2013; Sillars et al., 2004). All of these behaviors express aggression or disagreement in an indirect manner that can shut down discussion about the conflict issue.

For instance, rather than discussing optimal punishment in a calm manner that facilitates cooperation, Doug and Mary might show hostility through indirect behaviors. Doug might try to explain his philosophy—that Amanda needs to learn there are consequences associated with smoking—in a condescending tone that makes Mary feel he is talking to her as if she is a child. Mary's response may be to sigh, roll her eyes, and cross her arms over her chest in a defensive manner. Doug might then complain, in a hostile voice, that Mary isn't even listening. Such tactics could result in one or both of the partners leaving the scene in frustration. In this type of scenario, the indirect behaviors often provoke metaconflict, which we defined earlier as conflict about how people disagree. Mary might demand, "Stop talking to me as if I'm a child," and Doug might complain, "We never get anywhere because you don't listen to me." Metaconflict often sidetracks partners away from discussing the issue at hand—in this case, how to best teach Amanda a lesson about smoking.

Indirect fighting may be especially destructive when partners use these behaviors to avoid confronting problems (Sillars et al., 2004). A study of conflict in parent-child relationships showed that people report using more indirect fighting when their partner has an avoidant personality type (La Valley & Guerrero, 2012). Therefore, people may resort to indirect fighting when they feel that they are being dismissed or ignored by their partners. Indirect fighting reflects a level of hostility that is not found in other indirect styles of conflict management. As discussed next, avoiding is more neutral than indirect fighting, and yielding is more cooperative. Indirect fighting is related to many of the same negative outcomes as the competitive fighting, including relationship dissatisfaction and a failure to resolve conflicts. However, indirect fighting may be even more detrimental to relationships than competitive fighting because it is an indirect strategy. At least competitive fighting involves engaging in direct, verbal communication that might bring important issues to the forefront. As you will learn later in this chapter, behaviors associated with indirect fighting, such as rolling one's eyes, sounding disgusted or fed up, and ignoring one's partner, have been identified as signs of unproductive conflict that can lead to relationship decline (Gottman, 1994). People who employ indirect

fighting are also perceived as less effective and appropriate than are those who use cooperative strategies (Guerrero, 2013).

Avoiding

Avoiding is an indirect style of conflict that is regarded as somewhat neutral in terms of how cooperative versus uncooperative it is. This style has also been called *inaction* (Klein & Johnson, 1997; Pruitt & Carnevale, 1993) and *nonconfrontation* (Putnam & Wilson, 1982). When using the avoiding style, people refrain from arguing and refuse to confront their partners in any meaningful way. Avoiding tactics are fairly common. Studies have shown that roommates frequently report using the avoiding style in their conflicts (Sillars, 1980), and 63% of college students report withholding at least one complaint from their dating partners (Roloff & Cloven, 1990). People who use the avoiding strategy engage in tactics such as denying the conflict, being indirect and evasive, changing or avoiding topics, acting as if they don't care, making irrelevant remarks, and joking to avoid dealing with the conflict (Hocker & Wilmot, 2013).

Imagine that Mary and Doug deal with their disagreement by using the avoiding style. Neither of them wants to confront the issue, so they avoid talking about how to best handle the situation with Amanda. Perhaps they both punish Amanda their own way, without consulting the other, making Amanda suffer two punishments instead of one. Or perhaps they both decide not to do anything, letting Amanda "off the hook" for smoking. Either way, the use of avoidance would lead to a lose-lose situation, with little being accomplished. Consistent with this example, several studies have shown that the avoiding style is evaluated as inappropriate and ineffective (Canary & Spitzberg, 1987, 1989, 1990; Gross & Guerrero, 2000; Gross et al., 2004).

Occasionally, though, avoidance may be beneficial. Roloff and Ifert (2000) described five conditions that influence whether avoidance has a positive or negative effect on relationships. First, avoidance may be an effective strategy for certain types of couples. Couples who find it difficult to engage in conflict without resorting to aggression may find avoidance preferable to engagement. Second, avoidance is more acceptable when accompanied by expressions of positive affect. So if Doug says, "I'm too tired to talk about this anymore, honey" with a warm voice and genuine smile, Mary might empathize with him rather than feeling dismissed. Third, people are most likely to respond positively to avoidance when the topic is of little importance to both people. As Hocker and Wilmot (2013) noted, the avoidant style can be used to acknowledge that a relationship is more important than a particular issue.

Fourth, individuals are more likely to find avoidance acceptable if it is their decision to avoid discussion about a particular topic. When people feel their partners are pressuring them to keep quiet about relational issues that are bothering them, avoidance may have an especially harmful effect on the relationship. Finally, when people are socially skilled communicators, they may be able to recognize when avoidance is appropriate versus inappropriate. For example, imagine that Doug is staunchly conservative and Mary is extremely liberal. If they are socially skilled, they might be flexible enough to "agree to disagree" when it comes to political issues but to confront conflict issues revolving around Amanda and her twin sister, Megan.

Yielding

The yielding style is cooperative and indirect (Klein & Johnson, 1997; Pruitt & Carnevale, 1993; Sillars, 1980). People who use this style forgo their own goals and desires in consideration of the partner (Kilmann & Thomas, 1977). This style has also been labeled *obliging* (Rahim, 1986) and *accommodating* (Blake & Mouton, 1964). Papa and Canary (1995) noted that this type of response is adequate and comfortable; it does not cause further disagreement or escalation of conflict. However, the yielding style glosses over differences, plays down disagreements, and trivializes conflict, making effective conflict management difficult. Hocker and Wilmot (2013) described several specific yielding tactics, including putting aside one's own needs to please the partner, passively accepting the partner's decisions, and making conciliatory statements.

Mary or Doug might engage in any or all of these tactics as part of a yielding response. Suppose Doug decides to give in to Mary and grounds Amanda. He might tell Mary that she is right, that he'll just have to deal with having Amanda at home, and that he loves his family and hopes it works out. Doug may yield for many different reasons. Perhaps he really does believe that Mary knows best when it comes to disciplining Amanda. Or perhaps he decides that it is not worth arguing over and he will simply let Mary have her way. Yet another possibility is that he feels threatened or coerced. In their research on the **chilling effect**, Cloven and Roloff (1993) found that people are likely to avoid voicing their opinions and complaints when they feel powerless or fear that their partner will act aggressively toward them (see also [Chapter 12](#)).

Yielding occurs for many different reasons, so it can be perceived as both competent and incompetent (Gross & Guerrero, 2000). Yielding behavior is cooperative and appropriate when one person feels strongly about an issue and the other person does not. In such cases, it is appropriate for the person who feels less strongly to give in to the partner. Yielding may also be an appropriate strategy when two people cannot agree but a decision must be made. For instance, if Mary and Doug are arguing over who is going to pick Amanda up after a party (each believes it is the other's turn), one of them might give in so that Amanda will have a safe ride home.

However, most research suggests that although the yielding style is sometimes appreciated by one's partner, it is generally ineffective (Gross & Guerrero, 2000; Papa & Canary, 1995). People who use the yielding style are unlikely to achieve personal goals, which could strain their relationship. According to Hocker and Wilmot (2013), repeatedly yielding puts a person in a powerless position. Perhaps this is why people seldom report yielding when the conflict issue is important to them. Sillars (1980) examined how often roommates reported using yielding strategies. He had students recall significant disagreements with their roommates and describe how they and their roommates communicated. Only 2% of the students reported using yielding strategies during their most significant roommate disagreements. By contrast, 33% of students perceived their roommates to have yielded during these same disagreements. Sillars suggested that the discrepancy occurred because students reported on a disagreement that was significant to them, which made it less likely that they would yield. Their roommates, conversely, may not have seen these disagreements as significant and so were willing to concede the issue. This finding suggests that yielding is more common when people do not care much about an issue.

Patterns of Conflict Interaction

Although people have tendencies to manage conflict in particular ways, people often use different strategies depending on the situation, the type of conflict, and the channel of communication. (See [Box 11.3](#) for how people sometimes switch from one channel of communication to another to help manage conflict.) Conflict strategies are not mutually exclusive. In other words, people can use more than one strategy during a single conflict interaction. For example, Doug and Mary may begin with the intention of communicating in a cooperative, direct manner but become increasingly competitive as they both stubbornly hang on to their original positions. They might also exhibit different conflict styles altogether. Perhaps Mary favors indirect fighting whereas Doug prefers to yield. As these examples illustrate, understanding various conflict styles in isolation does not paint a very good picture of how conflict interaction unfolds. This is why researchers have sought to understand common patterns of conflict within relationships. Next, we discuss four such patterns: (1) negative reciprocity, (2) demand-withdraw, (3) the **four horsemen of the apocalypse**, and (4) accommodation.

Negative Reciprocity

Despite the fact that indirect and competitive fighting usually have negative effects on relationships, people use these strategies more frequently than cooperative strategies (Canary et al., 1995; Sillars, 1980). This may be because of the **principle of negative reciprocity**, a pattern whereby aggression begets more aggression. Once one person uses competitive or indirect fighting, the other person is likely to follow suit. Patterns of negative reciprocity have even been found online. In a study looking at **flaming**, which is defined as a “hostile expression of emotions” online through means such as “swearing, insults, and name-calling,” Lee (2005) noted that “once started, flaming begets more flaming” (p. 393). People can also “flame” nonverbally by doing things like typing an insulting word or phrase in bold or all caps, or putting exclamations after statements such as “How can anyone be so stupid?!!!!”

Whether people are face to face or communicating online, hostile behaviors tend to be reciprocated during conflict (Gottman, 1994; Krokoff, Gottman, & Roy, 1988). Alberts and her colleagues (Alberts, 1989; Alberts & Driscoll, 1992) found that if a partner launches a complaint, the other partner is likely to fire back with a countercomplaint. Moreover, individuals in dissatisfying relationships were twice as likely as individuals in satisfying relationships to respond to complaints by denying the validity of the complaint or by escalating the hostility of the interaction (Alberts & Driscoll, 1992). Patterns of negative reciprocity also distinguish couples who are dissatisfied and violent from those who are dissatisfied but nonviolent. Violent couples are most likely to engage in high levels of negative reciprocity and low levels of **positive reciprocity** (Smith, Vivian, & O’Leary, 1990).

In conflict interaction, negative reciprocity appears to be more common than positive reciprocity. In a classic study, Gaelick, Brodenshausen, and Wyer (1985) studied how perceptions of a partner’s behavior influence patterns of reciprocity during conflict. They found that people enact positive behaviors when they perceive their partner is expressing affectionate emotions and negative behavior when they perceive their partner is

expressing hostile emotions. However, negative reciprocity was the main pattern for two reasons. First, people exhibit more negative than positive emotion in conflict situations. Second, and perhaps more importantly, people perceived their partners were expressing hostility even when they were not. For instance, imagine that Mary offers her view using a neutral voice, but Doug interprets her tone to be condescending. This could set off a chain of negativity, even though Mary's initial comment was not meant to be hostile.

Box 11.3 Tech Talk: Motives for Channel Switching during Conflict Interaction

When people think about interpersonal conflict, they usually think of two people arguing face to face. However, in the 21st century considerable conflict occurs in computer-mediated contexts, such as through texting, snapping, and other forms of instant messaging. A study by Scissors and Gergle (2013) found that conflicts that start within a mediated channel (such as texting) often continue face to face, sometimes face-to-face conflict is abandoned in favor of discussing the issue via a mediated channel, and other times people go back and forth between channels. For instance, the topic could come up while texting, be discussed further face to face, and then revisited and finally resolved with an exchange of text messages. This study also found the following four motivations for switching channels during conflict:

To Avoid Conflict Escalation: Conflict might be started in a mediated channel to ease into a discussion before moving it to a face-to-face context, or it might move from texting or instant messaging to face to face because one party believes he or she is being misinterpreted. Other times moving from face to face to texting can minimize conflict escalation because messages are shorter, and people have more time to think before replying, all of which can result in a calmer discussion.

To Manage Emotion: Sometimes people move from face to face into mediated channels because they feel more in control of their emotions when texting or instant messaging than when talking face to face. They can represent their emotions in a photo or an emoji, which may make them feel less vulnerable than they would expressing emotions face to face. Similarly, people sometimes feel they can more carefully express their feelings through a channel such as text because they would not get overwhelmed and blurt out the wrong thing. Other times, people feel that the depth of their emotions can be expressed better in face-to-face communication or that the delay in text messages will make them more anxious or angry.

To Adjust to Partner Preferences: Sometimes people accommodate to each other's channel preferences in an effort for the discussion to progress more smoothly. For example, if Doug does not like to argue on text, he might read Mary's message and not respond, prompting her to call him or wait until she gets home to talk. If Amanda prefers to deal with conflict issues through text, Mary and Doug might send her a group chat to discuss something that is bothering them.

To Resolve the Conflict: Conflict does not always get resolved during a single interaction. Sometimes channel switching helps provide a concluding segment to a conflict. In Scissors and Gergle's (2013) study, some people felt that face-to-face communication is necessary if a conflict is truly to be resolved, so moving from a mediated context to face to face was a way to conclude the conflict. Other times people felt that summarizing or apologizing using texting after a face-to-face conversation was a helpful way to resolve and shut down the conflict. So Amanda might text her parents the next day and say she is sorry for smoking and reiterate that she accepts their punishment.

These motivations suggest that channel switching can be very useful for managing conflict. Being aware of the advantages and disadvantages of different channels, such as face to face versus texting versus snapping, as well as understanding what channels your partner is most comfortable with, can lay the foundation for productive problem solving.

Patterns of negative reciprocity can be set off by a variety of hostile behaviors, including sarcasm, personal criticism, name-calling, yelling, and unfair accusations. Four other tactics have been found to be especially likely to divert attention away from the conflict issue while escalating negativity—(1) **gunnysacking**, (2) **kitchen sinking**, (3) bringing third parties into the argument, and (4) **mind reading**. Gunnysacking occurs when people store up old grievances and then dump them on their partner during a conflict (Bach & Wyden, 1970). Rather than discussing each issue when it first surfaces, issues are placed in a metaphorical gunnysack and presented all at once. Kitchen sinking is similar to gunnysacking. However, instead of storing up complaints, people rehash their old arguments when they get into a new argument (Bach & Wyden, 1970). Because gunnysacking and kitchen sinking involve multiple attacks, partners are likely to feel defensive and overwhelmed, making it difficult to discuss any of the issues productively.

Bringing third parties into an argument can also promote defensiveness. There are at least four ways that people do this. First, people mention things that other people said as a form of evidence (“Your sister warned me you can be really picky”). Such comments are especially hurtful and hard for receivers to defend because they cannot confront the person who supposedly made them. Second, people can badmouth the partner’s friends or family by making comments such as “I guess your erratic behavior shouldn’t surprise me—your whole family acts that way.” Statements like these make people particularly defensive. Not only do they have to defend themselves but they have to defend their friends or family. Third, individuals compare their partner unfavorably to other people (“None of my other girlfriends ever complained about that”), which is an especially frustrating type of personal attack. Fourth, people can make their conflicts public by telling their social networks, or, worse yet, taking the conflict online. Doing so tends to create drama, which makes problems worse. In a study based on interviews with teenagers, Marwick and Boyd (2014) defined **drama** as “interpersonal conflict that takes place in front of an active, engaged audience, often on social media” (p. 1191). For example, two people may post comments (either directly to the person or as a subtweet) that others will favorite, retweet, or comment on, creating a public war that only exacerbates problems.

Mind reading occurs when people assume that they know their partner’s feelings, motives, and behaviors. Gottman (1994) gave the following examples to illustrate mind reading: “You don’t care about how we live” and “You get tense in situations like this one” (p. 2). Imagine someone saying these things to you even though they were not true. Your partner would be assuming that you do not care and that you get tense instead of listening and verifying how you really feel. Because your partner’s guesses are wrong, defensiveness is likely to ensue and you are likely to be frustrated and even offended that your partner could misinterpret you so much. Gottman also noted that mind reading statements often include words such as *always* or *never*. As such, mind reading violates two principles of fair fighting: (1) it is often based on jumping to conclusions and (2) it is usually based on overgeneralizations. Conversational data collected by Alberts and Driscoll (1992) on complaints illustrates this point. In this scenario, Charles is upset because Cindy assumed that if he did a favor for her, he would hold it against her in some way. He tells her that he does not mind doing favors for her and would not expect anything in return. Eventually, Charles says this to Cindy:

When you tell me what I was going to say, it’s almost always wrong. I mean it’s wrong, and it’s infuriating and it drives me nuts. Like you really know me so well, that you know exactly what I’m going to say. And it’s never ever true. It’s never the correct answer. It’s what you want to believe I’m going to decide. (Alberts & Driscoll, 1992, p. 404)

Regardless of what specific behaviors couples use, those who engage in patterns of negative reciprocity report less relational satisfaction (Gottman, 1979). Dissatisfied couples also become increasingly hostile during discussions about problems or conflict issues, while satisfied couples maintain a consistently lower level of hostility (Billings, 1979; Gottman & Levenson, 1992). This does not mean that couples in satisfying relationships never display negative reciprocity. On the contrary, research suggests that negative reciprocity is a fairly common pattern in conflict interaction. The key appears to be the percentage of behaviors that are negative versus positive. Gottman’s (1994) research demonstrates that happy couples tend to engage in about

five positive behaviors for every negative behavior, whereas the ratio of negative-to-positive behaviors was about one to one for unhappy couples.

Demand-Withdraw

Researchers have identified another common but dysfunctional conflict sequence called the **demand-withdraw interaction pattern** (Gottman & Levenson, 1988; Sagrestano, Heavey, & Christensen, 2006). This pattern occurs when one person wants to engage in conflict or makes demands on a partner and the other wants to avoid it. The person in the demanding position is likely to be in a less powerful position (relative to the partner) and tends to be dissatisfied with something. By contrast, the person in the withdrawing position is likely to be in a more powerful position and to be happy with the status quo. Married couples are more likely to engage in the demand-withdrawal pattern when one partner desires more closeness or involvement in the home and the other partner desires more autonomy (Sagrestano et al., 2006). This pattern has been found in several different cultures (see [Box 11.4](#)).

The demand-withdrawal pattern can move in both directions—increased demands can lead to more withdrawal, but increased withdrawal can also lead to more demands (Klinetob & Smith, 1996). In fact, couples who use the demand-withdrawal pattern may have problems of **punctuation** (Watzlawick et al., 1967), with each partner “punctuating” the cause of the conflict differently. One partner might say, “I have to nag you all the time because you always withdraw,” whereas the other partner might say, “I have to withdraw because you are always nagging me.” Notice that both partners blame the other for their behavior.

Box 11.4 Around the World: Demand-Withdraw in Different Countries

Demand-withdraw is a common pattern of conflict interaction around the world. People from Australia, Brazil, Italy, Pakistan, Taiwan, and the United States all report being less satisfied and more distressed within their relationships if their conflict is characterized by the demand-withdraw pattern (Christensen, Eldridge, Catta-Preta, Lim, & Santagata, 2006; Noller & Feeney, 1998; Rehman & Holtzworth-Munroe, 2006). In contrast, across different cultures, couples who report using constructive conflict patterns that include compromising and collaborating report high levels of relational satisfaction.

Despite these consistencies, there are also some differences between cultures. In the study by Christensen and colleagues, Brazilians reported higher levels of demand-withdraw than did people from Italy, Taiwan, and the United States. There are also differences in how people from different countries engage in demanding behavior. For example, compared to U.S. wives, Pakistani wives tend to be less assertive when demanding change (Rehman & Holtzworth-Munroe, 2006). In fact, Pakistani husbands were more likely than Pakistani wives to engage in behavior that was aggressive and demanding, and Pakistani wives were more likely than Pakistani husbands to engage in withdrawal. This pattern is opposite to that found in some studies of couples from the United States, where wives are more likely to demand and husbands are more likely to withdraw. One possible explanation for these findings is that the power structure in marriage is different in some countries than others, with women less likely to be aggressive and more likely to withdraw in non-equalitarian cultures where men have considerably more power than women. In these non-equalitarian cultures, gender roles may outweigh other factors to determine who is more demanding versus withdrawing.

The demand-withdrawal pattern is most likely to occur when the conflict engager uses either competitive or indirect fighting. Engagers who use cooperative strategies are rarely perceived as demanding (Heavey, Christensen, & Malamuth, 1995). Because the demand-withdrawal pattern consists of uncooperative behavior, it is generally seen as an incompetent form of dyadic communication (Christensen & Shenk, 1991; Gottman & Levenson, 1988). Yet the effect this pattern of conflict communication has on relationships is not clear. Some studies have shown that couples characterized by the demand-withdrawal pattern are more likely to be dissatisfied with their relationships and, eventually, to break up. Yet other studies have shown that couples who use the demand-withdrawal sequence are likely to report increased relational satisfaction over time (Caughlin & Vangelisti, 2006). It may be that couples who break free from this sequence end up reporting more satisfaction because important changes were made in their relationships, whereas those who repeatedly follow this pattern become increasingly dissatisfied.

A more consistent finding is that women are more likely to do the demanding whereas men are more likely to do the withdrawing (Caughlin & Vangelisti, 1999; Christensen & Shenk, 1991; Gottman, 1994; Heavey, Layne, & Christensen, 1993). Imagine if Doug approaches Mary to discuss Amanda's punishment, but Mary tells him she does not want to talk about it anymore. Would this situation seem more believable if it were reversed—with Mary wanting to talk about the problem and Doug retreating? The research suggests it would, and that women may be in the demanding role more often because they are more likely to want to institute change in their relationships. However, this sex difference reverses if the conflict involves something the man wants to change (Kluwer, De Dreu, & Buunk, 1998; Sagrestano et al., 2006). In fact, a recent study looking at marital conflict in the home showed that husbands and wives were equally likely to be in either the demander or withdrawer role and that demand-withdrawal sequences were most likely when couples were discussing relationship issues that one partner had initiated (Papp, Kouros, & Cummings, 2009). So if Doug thinks it is unfair that he always ends up having to tell his daughters what their punishments are, he would probably be in

the demanding role when he and Mary discuss who will tell Amanda that she must volunteer at the hospital. Finally, some evidence suggests that couples characterized by husband-to-wife violence are more likely than nonviolent couples to exhibit rigid patterns of husband demand and wife withdrawal (Caughlin & Vangelisti, 2006). Olson (2002b) also found that couples who spontaneously engage in reciprocal violence during conflict are often caught in a demand-withdraw conflict pattern.

Overall, then, research has shown that the demand-withdrawal pattern is more prevalent in relationships where violence is present and, in such relationships, men are just as likely to be the demanders and women are just as likely to be the withdrawers (Babcock, Waltz, Jacobson, & Gottman, 1993; Berns, Jacobson, & Gottman, 1999; Holtzworth-Munroe, Smutzler, & Stuart, 1998; Ridley & Feldman, 2003). To manage conflict constructively and maintain a happy relationship, couples must learn to break this cycle. The person in the demanding role needs to be patient and persistent without becoming aggressive or violent. The person in the withdrawing role needs to listen and try to understand and empathize with the partner. With effort, the cycle can be broken and the relationship can become more satisfying.

The Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

Gottman's extensive research on the causes of divorce uncovered another especially destructive pattern of conflict called "the four horsemen of the apocalypse." According to Gottman (1994), couples who divorce are likely to exhibit a conflict pattern that includes the following four types of communication: (1) criticism, (2) defensiveness, (3) contempt, and (4) stonewalling, with contempt and stonewalling particularly toxic to relationships (Gottman, 1994; Lisitsa, 2013b). Gottman's research suggests that within the first three minutes of an interaction, the presence of these forms of communication can predict divorce with an accuracy rate of over 90%. The Gottman Institute offers antidotes or alternatives for the four horsemen that will lead to communicating in a more positive manner (Lisitsa, 2013a). The four horsemen and their antidotes are described next, with examples shown in [Box 11.5](#).

Criticisms VERSUS Complaints

Criticisms are personal attacks that blame someone else for a problem. **Complaints**, on the other hand, focus on a specific behavior. Gottman (1994) noted that often complaints are healthy. If relational partners never complained, they would be unable to improve their relationships by changing problematic behavior.

Criticisms, in contrast, are not healthy. Because they focus on attacking and blaming the partner, they lead people to feel hurt and rejected, and therefore often trigger an escalation of conflict that includes the other more-deadly horsemen. Criticisms can revolve around personal characteristics, including negative remarks about personality or appearance. For example, Amanda might tell Megan, "You are an inconsiderate and rude sister" or "If you weren't so fat your clothes wouldn't take up so much closet space." Criticism can also focus on performance (Alberts, 1988). In this case, someone dislikes the way something was done. For example, Doug might complain that Mary does not do a good job helping Amanda with her geometry homework by saying, "You're not explaining that very well. The way you described the theorem is confusing. Do you even know what you're doing?" This type of complaint can be frustrating because it implies that someone is not doing something the proper way. Indeed, Mary might respond by getting up from the table and telling Doug

to help her himself!

As you can probably guess, the antidote to a criticism is a complaint that focuses on a specific behavior without assigning blame. Luckily, research has shown that behavioral complaints are more common than criticisms revolving around personal characteristics, appearance, or performance (Alberts, 1988, 1989), yet when people are upset or frustrated about something, it is easy for them to blame the other person and fall into personal criticism. Focusing on the behavior, however, will be more productive in the long run.

Box 11.5 Highlights: Examples of the Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse and their Antidotes

Negative Behavior

Criticism:

"I can't believe how much space you hog up in the closet. You are so inconsiderate and rude!"

Defensiveness:

"Well, if you weren't on your cell phone all the time maybe we could actually spend some quality time together without having to do anything special."

Contempt:

"I need some damn help! All you do is sit there on your butt watching T.V. while I fix dinner and tend to the kids. I worked just as hard, actually harder, than you did today. You are just lazy and self-absorbed."

Stonewalling:

"Just stop yacking and let me watch T.V. I'm really not interested in anything you have to say."

Antidote

Complaint:

"I think it's important that we divide the closet space evenly. I don't like when my clothes are all scrunched together."

Accepting Responsibility:

"You're right. I should make more of an effort to plan things for us to do together. When things at school settle down I promise I will."

Showing Respect:

"I know that you're tired after working all day and your job is really important. I'm tired too. I would really appreciate it if you could help with dinner and then we can both relax."

Physiological Self-Soothing:

"Let's take a break and calm down. In about a half an hour we can regroup and talk again when we're both in a better frame of mind to try to work this out."

Defensiveness VERSUS Accepting Responsibility

People become defensive when they feel a need to protect themselves and ward off personal attacks, such as the types of criticism mentioned above. **Defensiveness** involves defending oneself by communicating "it's not me, it's you." Gottman (1994) listed several defensive forms of communication, including denying responsibility for a problem, making excuses, issuing counter-complaints, whining, making accusations to deflect responsibility from oneself, and mind reading. Other behaviors discussed previously, such as gunnysacking and kitchen-sinking, can also be used in an attempt to deflect the blame from oneself and direct it toward one's partner.

Defensiveness is a natural response to being attacked, but in most conflict situations both partners have some

responsibility for the issues that are causing problems. So the antidote for defensiveness is to fight the impulse to defend oneself and instead accept at least partial responsibility. The Gottman Institute gives this example to illustrate the difference between responding defensively versus accepting responsibility: A wife asks her husband, “Did you call Betty and Ralph to let them know that we’re not coming tonight as you promised this morning?” The husband could respond defensively by saying, “I was just too darn busy today. As a matter of fact, you know just how busy my schedule was. Why didn’t you just do it?,” or he could accept responsibility by saying, “Oops, I forgot. I should have asked you this morning to do it because I knew my day would be packed. Let me call them right now” (Lisitsa, 2013b). Notice that the defensive response deflects blame on the wife, while the second response not only admits responsibility, but also promises action to remedy the situation.

Contempt VERSUS Showing Respect

Showing contempt is one of the most destructive forms of communication that can occur in a relationship. **Contempt** communicates an air of superiority and is often the byproduct of long-standing problems in a relationship. When people feel they cannot solve their relational issues and their relationship is stagnating, they are often frustrated and perceive their partner as the problem. This can lead to contemptuous behaviors that go beyond blame and criticism. Nonverbal behaviors, such as sighing while someone is talking or rolling one’s eye communicate contempt. So do many other forms of communication. As Gottman (1994) stated:

Contempt is also easy to identify in speech. It involves any insult, mockery, or sarcasm or derision, of the person. It includes disapproval, judgment, derision, disdain, exasperation, mockery, put downs, or communicating that the other person is absurd or incompetent. Three types of contempt are hostile humor, mockery, or sarcasm. In this form of contempt, there may be derision, a put down, or cold hate. There is often a definite sense of distance, coldness, and detachment in this category of behavior. (p. 25)

Statements such as “you’re crazy” or “You can’t do anything right” are prototypical ways of communicating contempt. The Gottman Institute also gives the example of a wife coming home after an exhausting day and seeing her husband lounging on the couch. When she asks him to help her with dinner he replies by saying he’s too tired, after which she lights into him and says: “You’re ‘tired’?! Cry me a river.... I’ve been with the kids all day, running around like mad to keep this house going and all you do when you come home from work is flop down on that sofa like a child and play those idiotic video games. I don’t have time to deal with another kid.... Just try, try to be more pathetic” (Lisitsa, 2013b). Notice that the insults are not only more pointed than typical criticism (e.g., she calls him a pathetic child), but they imply that she is superior to him.

The antidote for contempt is to try and put yourself in your partner’s place and show some respect, which is the opposite of contempt. This can be difficult, but to get respect people need to show respect. Not feeling respected can be toxic in a relationship.

Stonewalling VERSUS Physiological Self-Soothing

Stonewalling usually occurs after a conflict pattern (including criticism, defensiveness, and contempt) has become pervasive in the relationship. At this point, one or both people shut down and withdraw from the interaction. Interaction seems futile and the withdrawing partner usually experiences heightened anxiety and a rapid pulse rate such that he or she just wants to get away. Partners are no longer trying to work problems out and instead avoid each other, tune out, act busy, and generally separate from each other. Sometimes one partner engages in stonewalling behavior while the other is still trying to fix things, which leads to the demand-withdrawal type of pattern discussed previously in this chapter. Although it usually takes time for stonewalling to occur, once it does it tends to become a habit. If this habit is not broken, Gottman's research suggests that relationships become stagnant and couples are likely to break up.

The antidote for stonewalling is **physiological self-soothing**. This method involves taking a break from the conflict, usually by telling your partner that you are feeling too much emotion and need to step away for a while to calm down and regain your thoughts. The Gottman Institute suggests that the break be at least 20 minutes long so that you can calm down sufficiently and let go of any negative feelings that could lead to defensiveness or contempt (Lisitsa, 2013a). Doing something pleasant during the break, such as reading or watching a T.V. show you enjoy, can be helpful so that you can regroup and go back to the discussion in the right frame of mind.

When emotions kick in and couples find themselves stonewalling, they should take a break from one another and do something pleasant for around 20 to 30 minutes so that they can calm down and be in a positive frame of mind to resume discussion.



Accommodation

For people to be able to successfully substitute the antidotes for the four horsemen of the apocalypse, they need to be able to engage in accommodation. Rusbult's work helps explain why some couples are more able to do this than others using the idea of the **accommodation principle** (Rusbult, Bissonnette, Arriaga, & Cox, 1998; Rusbult, Verette, Whitney, Slovik, & Lipkus, 1991). This principle rests on three ideas. First, people have a tendency to retaliate or withdraw when their partner engages in negative behavior. This is consistent with the conflict patterns discussed previously. Negative behavior begets more negative behavior, demand leads to withdrawal and withdrawal leads to demand, and criticism and contempt lead to defensiveness and eventually stonewalling. Second, accommodation occurs when people are able to overcome these initial tendencies and engage in cooperative rather than uncooperative communication to maintain their relationships. Third, couples in satisfying, committed relationships more often use accommodation than couples in uncommitted or dissatisfying relationships (Rusbult, Olsen, Davis, & Hannon, 2001).

Several studies have supported the accommodation principle (e.g., Campbell & Foster, 2002; Duffy & Rusbult, 1986; Rusbult & Zembrodt, 1983; Wieselquist, Rusbult, Foster, & Agnew, 1999). These studies demonstrate that accommodation is most likely to occur in relationships characterized by high levels of commitment, satisfaction, and trust. However, accommodation may not always have positive effects on relationships. Rusbult and her colleagues (2001) noted that accommodation can cause relational problems, including power imbalances. As with the yielding strategy, if only one person is doing the accommodating (or yielding), that person may be in a powerless position that could eventually lead to relational dissatisfaction. Thus, the key to successful accommodation may be that it prompts a pattern of positive reciprocity, with both partners eventually engaging in cooperative strategies. This does not mean that all conflict behaviors need to be cooperative; indeed, it may be hard to refrain from using some uncooperative forms of communication when a conflict issue is particularly contentious. It does mean, however, that it is critical for partners to break escalating cycles of negativity by engaging in and responding positively to accommodation. Some research has even shown that couples who fail to reciprocate positive messages are more likely to report interpersonal violence (Smith et al., 1990).

There are many ways to accommodate a partner's negative behavior, including refraining from reacting angrily, using appropriate humor, or showing positive affect. Alberts and Driscoll's (1992) data on conversational complaints provide a nice example of accommodation that leads to a more productive interaction. They gave an example of a man (we'll call him Aaron) who complains to a woman (we'll call her Beth) that he cannot find his possessions because she always moves them when she cleans the house. The end of their conversation went this way:

Aaron: But, I mean, it's not like you do it on purpose. It's because you're absentminded.

Beth: Uh-huh. Yeah.

Aaron: And it's not like I don't do it either.

Beth: Yeah, I mean, I agree that things have to have their place ... if you put them in their place, then you know where they are and it saves you a lot of worry.

Aaron: Well, then, there's really no disagreement.

Beth: Yeah, that's the way things should be. It's just that sometimes we do things that are contrary to the things we agree on.

Notice that Aaron engaged in a personal attack when he called Beth "absentminded." Yet instead of reciprocating his hostility, Beth accommodated by expressing agreement (perhaps because she agreed that she did not do it "on purpose"). This led Aaron to admit that he sometimes does the same thing, which paved the way to ending the disagreement.

Being able to respond to negativity with positivity promotes relational satisfaction. In one study, couples in which people were nice only when the partner was nice were more likely to separate either one and a half, two and a half, or five years later than were couples in which the two people were nice regardless of whether their partners acted positively or negatively. As this study demonstrated, it is important for people to be positive when the partner is sad, angry, or inexpressive, as well as when the partner is happy. Gottman's (1994) recommendation that couples counterbalance every one negative statement with five positive statements appears to be very sound advice.

Explanations for Conflict Patterns

Questions likely follow as to why patterns such as negative reciprocity and demand-withdrawal are so common. If people care about their relationships, why don't they try to defuse a negative situation by accommodating and reacting with positivity? Sometimes people do respond positively, but often they find it hard to refrain from negativity because of emotions they feel, attributions they make, or their lack of communication skills. Complementing the discussion in this section, [Box 11.6](#) provides rules for fair fighting that help people avoid falling into the trap of negative reciprocity during conflict.

Emotional Flooding

During conflict situations, people often naturally experience aversive emotions, such as anger, hurt, and guilt (Guerrero, 2013). Earlier in this chapter, we defined conflict as occurring when people have incompatible goals. Similarly, people feel negative emotion when someone or something blocks or disrupts their goals. So, if Mary feels that Doug's plan for punishing Amanda interferes with her goal to teach Amanda the "right" kind of lesson about smoking, Mary is likely to feel frustrated and perhaps even angry. Interestingly, moderate levels of emotion may be helpful during conflict situations (T. S. Jones, 2000). When people feel low levels of emotion, they are unlikely to put much effort into resolving conflict issues. On the other hand, especially intense emotion is counterproductive during conflict interactions.

During conflict situations, negative emotions may become so intense that people automatically resort to the fight-or-flight response. Gottman (1994) suggested that **emotional flooding** occurs when people become "surprised, overwhelmed, and disorganized" by their partner's "expressions of negative emotion" (p. 21). When this happens, people often experience high levels of physiological arousal (including increased heart rate and higher blood pressure), have difficulty processing new information, rely on stereotyped thoughts and behaviors, and respond with aggression (fight) or withdrawal (flight). Thus, flooding contributes to negative patterns of communication that involve both uncooperative behavior and avoidance.

Several communication behaviors are associated with flooding. According to Gottman's (1994) research, if one partner becomes defensive, stubborn, angry, or whiny, the other partner is likely to experience emotional flooding. Other behaviors act as buffers against emotional flooding. If one partner expresses joy, affection, or humor during a conflict interaction, the other partner is less likely to experience emotional flooding. Situational variables also play a role. Zillman's (1990) work on the excitation transfer suggests that people who are highly aroused (due to either stress or physical exertion) before engaging in conflict are more likely to react aggressively—presumably because they are experiencing emotional flooding. When people experience emotional flooding, they sometimes say things they don't really mean, or things they wish they could take back. For example, relational partners who are experiencing intense emotion might call each other names or make statements such as "I hate you" or "I wish I never met you." In the moment, such statements seem true because people are filled with negative emotion. However, when they calm down, they realize they actually care deeply for each other. Other times, people make these kinds of statements to get a kind of emotional revenge. They know that they don't really hate the partner, but by saying "I hate you" they hope to hurt the

partner the way they themselves feel hurt.

Box 11.6 Highlights: Ten “Rules” for Constructive Conflict Management

Based on the situation, there are various ways to manage conflict effectively. However, based on the research reviewed in this chapter, the following 10 “rules” should serve people well in most conflict situations.

1. Avoid gunnysacking or bringing in everything but the kitchen sink.
2. Do not bring other people into the conflict unless they are part of the conflict.
3. Attack positions, not people (no name-calling, button pushing, or violence).
4. Avoid making empty relational threats.
5. If necessary, postpone conflict until your emotions cool down.
6. Try to understand your partner’s position by practicing active listening and avoiding mind reading.
7. Use behavioral complaints rather than personal criticisms.
8. Try to accommodate rather than get defensive when you feel like you are being attacked.
9. Try to validate your partner’s position by expressing agreement and positive affect rather than stonewalling or escalating conflict.
10. For every one negative statement or behavior, use five positive statements or behaviors.

When feeling hurt and uncertain, people sometimes lash out by engaging in **button pushing** or making empty relational threats. When people engage in button pushing, they purposely say or do something they know will be especially hurtful to the partner. This could entail bringing up a taboo topic, insulting the partner with an offensive name, or looking away when the partner is talking. The key is that the button pusher knows the words or behavior will bother the partner.

Empty threats involve suggestions to do something that the speaker does not really intend to do. For instance, someone might say, “If you see her again, I’ll break up with you” or “I can’t stand this anymore; I want a divorce” when the speaker in each case actually has no intention of terminating the relationship. Empty threats have at least two negative consequences. First, if someone does not follow through on these threats, the person will lose face, and the partner may think the person is bluffing during future interactions when this time the individual is really serious. As the old fairy tale warns, it is not wise to “cry wolf” too many times. Second, if someone threatens to end a relationship without really intending to, this could plant a seed for relationship termination. Research suggests that people go through a cognitive process of psychological separation before terminating close relationships (Duck, 1988). Therefore, if one partner continues talking about ending the relationship, the other partner might think about being single or about better relational alternatives. If this happens, the partner who delivered the threats moved the possibility of breaking up to the forefront of the other partner’s mind. Thus, empty relational threats are more likely to backfire than to solve problems.

Because people tend to become defensive or aggressive when they are emotionally flooded, it is advisable to avoid discussing conflict issues until both partners have calmed down. However, conflict should not be put off indefinitely. If necessary, couples might need to schedule a time to talk about issues that are bothering them. In the interim, each partner might want to write down their feelings. To illustrate, one of our students once told us about a writing technique that she and her husband used when they were feeling really angry with each

other. From their past experiences, they knew it was likely that conflict would escalate if they confronted each other when their emotions were running high. They thus decided to vent their negative emotions by going to different rooms and writing letters to each other. Later, after they had calmed down, they would each read the letters to themselves and decide whether to share them with the spouse. This student said that neither of them ever ended up sharing the letters but instead always tore them up. The letters were usually filled with things they did not really mean, such as exaggerations, name-calling, or unfair accusations. But these letters helped her and her husband put their conflict issues in perspective and enabled them to move on and discuss their problems in a calmer fashion.

Attributions

People like to be able to explain the behavior of others, particularly during significant events such as conflict episodes. To do this, people make attributions. In their book on interpersonal communication, Fisher and Adams (1994) defined an **attribution** as “a perceptual process of assigning reasons or causes to another’s behavior” (p. 411). This definition is consistent with Heider’s (1958) conception of people as “naive scientists” who study one another’s behavior and make judgments about why they act the way they do. People are especially likely to make attributions about negative behavior, including the uncooperative types of behaviors that often occur during conflict (Rolloff & Miller, 2006).

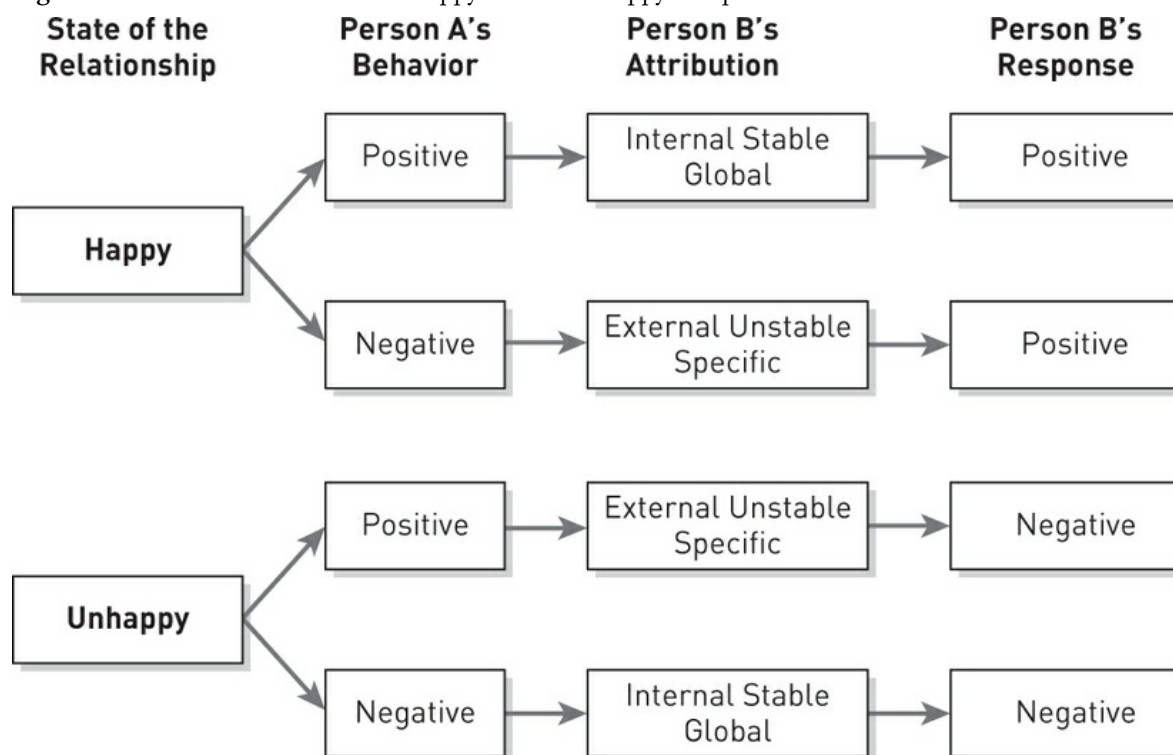
Three specific types of attributions have been studied extensively (Kelley, 1973). First, people attribute a person’s behavior to personal versus situational causes. When people make personal attributions, they believe that the cause of another person’s behavior is rooted in their personality. By contrast, when people make situational attributions, they believe that the other person’s behavior was affected by external factors, such as context or situation. For example, Doug might be upset because Mary ran out and got his birthday present at the last minute, causing them to be late for their dinner reservation. He could attribute Mary’s behavior to personality factors (Mary is forgetful and disorganized) or to situational factors (Mary has been especially busy with work and has had to drive Amanda to the hospital every day after work).

Second, people make attributions about behavior being stable versus unstable. In other words, is Mary usually too busy to prepare for Doug’s birthday? After many years of marriage, Doug might determine that her last-minute behavior is atypical and that she usually finds the time to buy him a nice gift no matter how busy she gets. Third, people make attributions about how global versus specific the cause of a behavior is. The more global a cause is, the greater number of behaviors and situations it applies to. For instance, the extra tasks with which Mary has been occupied might have caused her to put off doing things she normally does, or perhaps she just forgot about getting Doug a present.

Research on the **attribution hypothesis** has shown that patterns of attribution are related to conflict escalation and lower levels of satisfaction (Fincham, Harold, & Gano-Phillips, 2000). As [Figure 11.2](#) shows, people in happy relationships tend to make **relationship-enhancing attributions** by attributing negative behavior such as complaints, whining, and nagging to causes that are external, unstable, and specific. By contrast, people in unhappy relationships tend to make **distress-maintaining attributions** by attributing negative behavior to internal, stable, and global causes (Bradbury & Fincham, 1990; Brehm & Kassin, 1990; Harvey, 1987;

Holtzworth-Munroe & Jacobson, 1985). In general, people make more positive attributions about their own behavior than their partner's behavior during conflict, but partners in dissatisfying relationships are especially likely to blame their partners (Sillars, Roberts, Leonard, & Dun, 2000).

Figure 11.2 Attribution Patterns in Happy Versus Unhappy Couples



Since Doug and Mary are happily married, their pattern of attributions would most likely be relationship enhancing. For instance, if Mary becomes aggressive when Doug doesn't agree with her, he might think this: "She's just especially upset because her grandfather died of lung cancer and she's worried about Amanda. We can usually talk about disciplining our daughters without getting into a heated argument." On the other hand, if they were a dissatisfied couple, Doug might think this: "Mary is so stubborn. She always thinks she's right! We never agree about how to discipline our daughters—or anything else for that matter!"

As these examples suggest, when people attribute negative behavior to internal, stable, and global causes (as people in dissatisfying relationships tend to do), they are more likely to use uncooperative conflict behaviors, such as indirect and competitive fighting (Davey, Fincham, Beach, & Brody, 2001; Schweinle, Ickes, & Bernstein, 2002). This can lead to negative spirals in dissatisfying relationships. Couples in dissatisfying relationships are also more likely to pay attention to negative behaviors than positive behaviors and to attribute positive behaviors to negative causes. In some cases, these attributions represent habitual but inaccurate ways of perceiving the partner's behavior.

In other cases, negative attributions may be accurate. Amanda might resist her parents' advice about smoking because she is stubborn and rebellious (a personal cause), and Megan and Amanda might continually fight over family possessions, such as the phone and computer, because they both want privacy and autonomy (a stable cause). In conflict situations such as these, identifying the causes may be essential for managing the

conflict (Roloff & Miller, 2006). Therefore, it is essential—although difficult—to sort out inaccurate attributions from accurate attributions so that the true causes of conflict can be identified.

Communication Skill Deficits

In addition to emotional flooding and cognitive attributions, some people simply do not have the communication skills necessary to engage in constructive conflict. These individuals are likely to feel helpless and defensive when attacked by others because they cannot respond effectively. Thus, they resort to aggressive behaviors or withdrawal, which can contribute to negative spirals of behavior. People with communication or social skill deficits are also more likely to report using violence in their relationships (Christopher & Lloyd, 2000). These deficits include having difficulties in the following areas: general emotional expression, anger management, social support seeking and giving, and problem solving. Men with communication skill deficits are also less likely to make relationship-enhancing attributions for their partner's behavior (Holtzworth-Munroe & Hutchinson, 1993; Holtzworth-Munroe & Smutzler, 1996).

Argumentativeness VERSUS Aggressiveness

Another important communication skill is the ability to engage in logical argument. Infante and his colleagues distinguished between **argumentativeness** and **verbal aggressiveness** (Infante, 1987; Infante, Chandler, & Rudd, 1989; Infante & Rancer, 1982). Argumentativeness refers to conflict styles that focus on logical argument and reasoning: People with argumentative styles confront conflict directly by recognizing issues of disagreement, taking positions on controversial issues, backing up claims with evidence and reasoning, and refuting views contrary to their own. Argumentativeness is an important social skill. People who are skilled in argument do not have to resort to name-calling, accusations, or other negative tactics. Instead, they can present their positions in a skilled and convincing manner. Rather than attacking their partner, they attack their partner's position.

Verbal aggressiveness involves attacking the other person's self-concept, often with the intention of hurting the other person. Verbally aggressive people engage in such tactics as teasing, threatening, and criticizing the partner's character or appearance (Infante, Sabourin, Rudd, & Shannon, 1990). Infante's research has shown that people resort to these types of tactics when they are unskilled in argumentation. Partners in violent marriages are more likely to report high levels of verbal aggression and low levels of argumentativeness than are those in nonviolent marriages (Infante et al., 1989, 1990).

The following example illustrates how difficult it is to deal with someone who is verbally aggressive: Amanda and Megan are starting to think about where to apply for college, so they watch a news report on admission requirements at various universities. After the report, the sisters begin discussing their differing opinions on affirmative action.

Amanda: I can't believe they are going to prohibit affirmative action at State.

Megan: If you ask me, it's about time they did.

Amanda: You mean you are against affirmative action?

Megan: Let's put it this way: I think people should be admitted to universities based on their qualifications rather than their skin color.

Amanda: So you are a racist who hates minorities.

Megan: That's not true. I don't like discrimination in any form. I just think universities should make exceptions based on factors other than race. Poor white students are also disadvantaged. Maybe a policy that admits students based on where they rank in their particular high school would be fairer. That way, all students who are economically disadvantaged, including minority students, would get help.

Amanda: And I suppose you think that white men are discriminated against, too. I thought you were smarter than that. How can you be so gullible?

If you did not have a strong opinion about affirmative action policies before reading Amanda and Megan's comments, you may have been persuaded by Megan's arguments because they focused on her position rather than attacking Amanda as a person. In short, Megan used argumentative communication. By contrast, Amanda used verbal aggression when she called Megan a racist, implied she was unintelligent, and asked how she could be so gullible. If Amanda had used argumentative communication, you might have been persuaded by her argument rather than Megan's. This example also illustrates how verbally aggressive communication can lead to negative spirals. Put yourself in Megan's place. If the conversation continued—and you kept being attacked personally—would you have been tempted to retaliate by using verbal aggression yourself? Most people have a hard time remaining neutral in the face of personal attacks, partly due to emotional flooding.

Effective Listening

The ability to listen to others is another critical skill for effective conflict management. When people practice effective listening, they are better able to understand their partner's thoughts and feelings, and, ultimately, to empathize with their concerns. Such understanding plays a vital role in collaboration and compromise. In fact, studies have shown that people with listening and decoding skills (the ability to figure out what the partner is feeling) tend to be more satisfied in their relationships (Guerrero & Floyd, 2006).

Active listening is very challenging in conflict situations. For instance, think about the last heated argument you had with someone. How carefully did you listen to what the person said? If you felt attacked or became defensive, chances are that you did not really listen to the other person very carefully. Instead, you were probably thinking about what you would say next. Your mind may have been racing as you thought about how to defend yourself, and your emotions may have been so turbulent that you became preoccupied with your own thoughts and feelings and "tuned the other person out." Ironically, if the other person was not practicing active listening either, all the counterarguments you spent so much time creating would never really be heard.

Active listening thus requires effort and concentration. The experts on listening and negotiation give the following advice for improving active listening skills (Stark, 1994; Steil, Barker, & Watson, 1983; Stiff, Dillard, Somera, Kim, & Sleight, 1988):

1. *Let your partner speak.* Refrain from arguing your case or interrupting until your partner finishes stating her or his position. If you spend noticeably more time talking than your partner, this probably means that you need to talk less and encourage your partner to talk more.
2. *Put yourself in your partner's place.* Enter a conflict situation with specific goals regarding what you would like to learn from your partner. As Gottman (1994) emphasized, if people want to understand and empathize with each other, they need to create **mental maps** of each other's thoughts and feelings. By listening actively, people can see things from their partner's perspective.
3. *Don't jump to conclusions.* Don't assume you know what your partner will say or why they will say it. Making such assumptions can lead you to interpret your partner's statements in a way that is consistent with your preexisting beliefs—even if your preexisting beliefs are wrong.
4. *Ask questions.* Ask questions that allow your partner to clarify and explain her or his position. Be sure to phrase these questions in a positive manner so you don't sound sarcastic or condescending.
5. *Paraphrase what your partner says.* Paraphrase what you hear to confirm that you have really heard what your partner is trying to tell you. When partners paraphrase, they summarize each other's positions. This way partners have the opportunity to correct misinterpretations and to further clarify their positions.

Summary and Application

Conflict is inevitable in close relationships. The closer you are to someone, the more likely you will encounter disagreements. Disagreements can have positive or negative effects on relationships. When differences are handled cooperatively, conflict can improve relationships by helping partners solve problems and understand each other. But when negative patterns of conflict communication become pervasive, including those involving the four horsemen of the apocalypse, relational partners are likely to become less satisfied and committed and to feel less emotional closeness. When spouses argue, their conflict style can also impact their children's well-being. Children whose parents repeatedly engage in hostile patterns of conflict are less likely to have good peer relationships and more likely to use uncooperative conflict styles themselves. Conflict between parents and children also has a socializing effect on children. So if Amanda disagrees with her parents regarding her punishment, the way her parents communicate with her will likely influence how Amanda deals with conflict in other relationships in the future.

Doug and Mary have many options for dealing with conflict. They could engage in communication that is cooperative or uncooperative, direct or indirect. Although six separate styles of conflict are described in this chapter, Doug and Mary could use a variety of styles during a conflict interaction and each could use different styles of communication. Mary might be more direct than Doug, and Doug might be more cooperative than Mary. In addition, conflict interaction is a two-way street. It takes two people to escalate conflict; it also takes two people to cooperate.

Engaging in cooperative conflict requires communication skills. Many people use uncooperative strategies, such as competitive fighting and indirect fighting, which cause conflicts to escalate. It follows that negative patterns of conflict communication can develop in relationships. For example, some relational partners get caught in patterns of negative reciprocity, demand-withdrawal, or the four horsemen of the apocalypse. If Doug and Mary notice that their conflict interactions are characterized by plenty of personal criticism, contempt, defensiveness, or stonewalling, their relationship could be in trouble. Using the antidotes for the four horsemen of the apocalypse and engaging in patterns of accommodation, which involve responding to negative behavior with positive behavior, help diffuse negativity and promote cooperation.

Using the collaborating style would provide Mary and Doug with the best option for disciplining Amanda effectively. Mary and Doug would be more likely to reach a collaborative solution if they avoided destructive patterns of conflict communication and remained focused on their goals. The studies reviewed in this chapter point to several rules for constructive conflict management, which Mary and Doug would be advised to follow. These rules are summarized in [Box 11.6](#) and provide a blueprint for communicating effectively during conflict situations, as do the antidotes described in [Box 11.5](#).

Although the advice in this chapter probably makes sense to you, it may be hard for Mary and Doug (or any two people) to follow it all of the time. Even if you have good intentions and know how you *should* act during a conflict situation, when your emotions are running high, it is difficult not to violate some of these rules. If you find yourself engaging in some destructive tactics during conflict situations, do not panic—even experts in

negotiation make mistakes. Recognizing these mistakes is a first step toward managing conflict in ways that keep your relationships satisfying.

Key Terms

accommodation principle (p. 305)
argumentativeness (p. 310)
attribution (p. 308)
attribution hypothesis (p. 309)
avoiding (p. 288)
button pushing (p. 308)
chilling effect (p. 297)
collaborating (p. 287)
competitive fighting (p. 287)
compromising (p. 287)
complaints (p. 303)
conflict (p. 288)
contempt (p. 304)
criticisms (p. 303)
defensiveness (p. 304)
demand-withdraw interaction pattern (p. 301)
distress-maintaining attributions (p. 309)
drama (p. 300)
emotional flooding (p. 307)
empty threats (p. 308)
flaming (p. 298)
four horsemen of the apocalypse (p. 298)
gunnysacking (p. 300)
indirect fighting (p. 288)
kitchen sinking (p. 300)
mental maps (p. 312)
mind reading (p. 300)
physiological self-soothing (p. 305)
positive reciprocity (p. 298)
principle of negative reciprocity (p. 298)
punctuation (p. 301)
relationship-enhancing attributions (p. 309)
socialization effect (p. 290)
spillover effect (p. 290)
stonewalling (p. 305)
verbal aggressiveness (p. 310)
yielding (p. 288)

Discussion Questions

1. Do you tend to avoid or engage in conflict? Which of the six conflict styles discussed in this chapter best fits you? Does your style of communication stay fairly consistent, or does it vary a lot depending on the situation and the partner?
2. Think of times when you have used criticism, defensiveness, contempt, and stonewalling during a conflict. Now that you have read the research on the four horsemen of the apocalypse, what would you say or do differently? Try to recall what you said and then come up with a phrase you could have used to implement the antidote.
3. When people are in the midst of interpersonal conflict, they often are flooded with emotions. This makes it difficult to “fight fairly.” Which of the rules for constructive conflict management do you think is most difficult to follow? Do you have any additional suggestions that might help your classmates learn to manage conflict in more constructive ways?